

MULLEN IT OVER

By
Eddie
Mullens



Amarillo Gold Sox general manager-president Bob Scarlett and his capable business manager, Ben Niblock, were discussing the one thing that makes the baseball world go round—John A. Fan—at Potter County Stadium recently.

"Putting himself back from his desk, Scarlett said, 'Fans are the most important part of professional baseball. Of course this is certainly nothing new to hear but I feel that more baseball front office staffs are realizing that every effort should be made to make the average fan enjoy himself while attending a game.'"

The Gold Sox front office is NIBLOCK trying to find ways to make baseball more enjoyable for the fan. Last year, as you may well recall, the G-Sox management staged several promotional nights and have many planned for this year.

"How about our Fun-Go nights?" Niblock said. "If you recall it was introduced here last Tuesday night and over 90 per cent of the fans participated in the game. And I'd say well over 80 per cent of these remained afterward to check their names for the correct answers."

Scarlett moved back to his desk, picked up a Gold Sox program and turned to the back. "Here are the Eleven Commandments of good baseball," Scarlett said as he piled the book on my way.

The Commandments include: A fan is the most important person in baseball. A fan is not an interruption of our work—he is the cause of it. A fan is not dependent on us—we are dependent on him. A fan does us a favor when he calls—we are not doing him a favor by serving him. A fan is part of our business—not an outsider.

A fan is not a cold statistic—he is a flesh and blood human being with feelings and emotions like our own. A fan is not someone to argue with or make a fuss. A fan is a person who brings us his wants—it is our job to fill those wants. A fan is deserving of the most courteous and attentive treatment we can give him. A fan is the fellow who makes it possible to pay your salary whether you are a manager, player, ticket seller, ticket taker, usher, concession help or other park employee. A fan is the life blood of this and every other sports attraction.

"Ben and I were just talking about the special promotion nights we plan to have in the near future," Scarlett remarked.

One of these, Niblock pointed out, is the Silver Anklets vs. the Gold Sox night. This is the rib-tickling contest between the players' wives and the Gold Sox. In this contest, which is played with a softball, the G-Soxers must throw with the opposite hand they normally use.

"There will be seven ladies' nights held this year for the enjoyment of the feminine fans. "It was interesting to note more ladies attended each successive ladies' night in 1957. And in spite of the cold, over 310 ladies enjoyed the first ladies' night this year," Scarlett said.

"Most fans are quite easy to please. But I recall the story Andy Cohen, now manager of the Denver Bears, likes to tell," Scarlett said.

"It seems a hard situation was in order early in the game. Cohen considered his batter and decided he was not too fast or a good hunter. So Andy yelled for him to hit away. The batter grounded into a double play. Someone jumped up and yelled at Cohen, 'Have you ever heard of the bunt?'"

"Later in the game in a similar situation, Cohen decided to have the same batter bunt. The batter bunted too hard and as a result another double play. The same fan bounced up and belittled at Cohen, 'We always know you were bunt happy!'"